Analysis of Plato's Apology

The Apology is Plato's recollection and interpretation of the Trial of Socrates (399 BC). In this dialogue Socrates explains who he is and what kind of life he led. The Greek word "apologia" means "explanation" -- it is not to be confused with "apologizing" or "being sorry" for one's actions. The following is an outline of the 'argument' or logos that Socrates used in his defense. A hypertext treatment of this dialogue is also available.

I. Prologue (17a-19a)

The first sentence sets the tone and direction for the entire dialogue. Socrates, in addressing the men of Athens, states that he almost forgot who he was. The speeches of his accusers had led him to this point. The dialogue will thus be a kind of "recollecting" by Socrates of who he is. That is to say, the Apology will become Socrates' answer to the question: "WHO IS SOCRATES?"

II. The First False Charges (19a - 24a)

A. The Charges and Their Assignment (19a-20c)

The first "charges" against Socrates arose from GENERAL PREJUDICES that surrounded him over the years. These general accusations were that Socrates was: (1) a PHYSICALIST and (2) a SOPHIST. The charge of "investigating things beneath the earth and in the skies" belongs to a physicalists like Thales and Anaxagoras. The charge of "making the weaker argument appear the stronger" belongs to sophists like Gorgias, Hippias, and Evanus. In truth, Socrates IS NOT a Physicalist and Socrates IS NOT a Sophist.

B. Socrates' Art and the Delphic Oracle (20c-23c)

The false images of Socrates arose because people misunderstood his true activity. Socrates explains this activity by relating a story about the Delphic Oracle.

The Saying of the Delphic Oracle -- A friend of Socrates' went to the Oracle and asked the priestess "Who is the wisest of mortals?" and the priestess replied: "Socrates is the most wise."

When Socrates heard this he was surprised, since he thought of himself as "most ignorant."

The Testing of the Delphic Oracle -- After some hesitation, he sought to show the saying wrong by finding someone wiser than he. He began to question various people, including politicians, poets, and craftsmen.

In each encounter the person made a claim that he was in possession of some kind of wisdom or absolute knowledge. The knowledge relates to the spheres of what might be called value e.g., the problems of God, the Good, and the Beautiful.

The Truth of the Delphic Oracle -- After "testing" the saying of the god, Socrates became aware of the truth of the saying that "Socrates is most wise" -- it can be expressed as follows: Socrates was most wise because he was AWARE of his ignorance. (This is how Socratic Wisdom is related to Socratic Ignorance.)

And, in a profound sense, those around Socrates, those who claimed a "knowledge" in the sphere

of values, were ignorant of their ignorance.

C. How the Charges Arose (23c-24a)

In the course of Socrates' verification of the Delphic Oracle, many people had their beliefs and values questioned and cast into doubt.

The response of many to this experience was confusion and anger. Over the years, this anger took the form of a general RESENTMENT against Socrates.

III. The Specific Charges (24b - 28a)

The charges made by Meletus and Anytus were that Socrates was guilty of:

A. CORRUPTION OF THE YOUTH;

B. IMPIETY.

They demand the DEATH PENALTY.

Regarding the Charge of Corruption of the Youth -- Socrates begins a dialogue with his accuser Meletus. He defends himself by practicising his art.

1. Meletus says that Socrates is the person in Athens who is responsible for the corruption of the youth. Yet it is absurd to say that only Socrates corrupts the youth. This implies that everyone else helps the youth. But just as there are few horse trainers, so there are few who are in a postion to really "train" the youth. And, contrary to what Meleteus asserts, Socrates is one of these "trainers."

2. Who would voluntarily corrupt the youth? (25c-26a) If Socrates voluntarily harmed the youth, then (since evil begets evil) they would harm him. And no rational person voluntarily harms himself.

But if he harmed the youth involuntarily, then he should be instructed (educated) -- not punished.

Regarding the Charge of Impiety

Socrates next takes up the charge of Impiety. Could a person believe in things like clothes and yet not in human beings who wear them? So too with divine things: Since Socrates believes in a Diamon (a divine thing), it follows that he believes in divinities.

IV. Socrates' Interpretation of his Art (28b - 32e)

Socrates, far from being an impious corruptor of the youth, is actually a blessing sent by the gods.

To show this, Socrates likens himself to a GADFLY (a horsefly). Just as a gadfly constantly agitates a horse, preventiung it from becoming sluggish and going to sleep so too Socates, by (moving through the City) stirring up conversations in the marketplace, prevents the City from becoming sulggish and careless and intolerant (thinking it knows something when it doesn't).

Ultimately, Socrates' whole life had been a service to the City begun out of a pious response to the saying of the gods. This is the deeper refutation of the charges. It is also another positive image of Socrates: He IS a gadfly.

V. Socrates Answers the Charges (33a-34b)

[Notice the general movement of the defense --

Who Socrates IS NOT: He is NOT a Physicalist; he is NOT a Sophist.

Who Socrates IS: He IS someone who is AWARE OF HIS IGNORANCE.

Who Socrates IS NOT: He IS NOT a corruptor of the Youth; he IS NOT Impious.

Who Socrates IS: He IS like a Gadfly, helping the City out of a pious response to the Delphic Oracle.]

He asks, finally, if any present in the court felt that he had corrupted them. Plato and others indicate that, to the contrary, they have been helped by Socrates. Hence "those around him" also say that Socrates does not corrupt the youth.

VI. Epilogue (34c-35d)

Socrates tells the "men of Athens" that he wants to be judged according to his account of himself and not by any other standard -- such as appealing to his old age or the fact that he has children.

Thus Socrates wishes to be judged and not "forgiven" or let off for any other reason than that it is JUST to do so.

At this point, a vote is taken and Socrates is found quilty by a margin of some 30 votes).

VII. The Conviction and Alternate Penalties (36a - 38c)

Socrates is found guility by a margin of some 30 votes. The penalty proposed is death by hemlock. At this point Socrates has the opportunity to propose an alternate penalty.

Socrates argues that since the penalty should be something he deserves, and since he has spent his life freely offering his service to the City, he deserves FREE MEALS for the rest of his life.

VIII. Final Speeches (38c-42a)

There are two sets of final speeches. The first are to those who voted for his death; the second are for those who voted for his aquittal. It is only in the latter speech that Socrates uses the term "judges."

To those who voted for his death (38c-39d)

1. At his age of 70, death would have soon arrived naturally. But now these people will bear the responsibility for it -- and they will have allowed Athens to be condemned for its condemnation of Socrates.

2. Socrates notes that he could have won his case if he had appealed to their emotioins (i.e., if he had practiced Sophistry), but he chose instead to speak the Truth.

3. He prophesizes that there will be others to take his place. After all, it is not the particular person of Socrates which is at issue here, but the activity of Philosophy itself.

To those who voted for his aquittal (39e-42a)

Socrates notes that his Diamon never attempted to disuade him from anything that he said. So this outcome must be for the good. After all, death is either one of two things: a DEEP SLEEP or a CHANGE OF PLACE.

A deep sleep is quite peacefull, more so than most of our waking days.

If he were to enter Hades, on the other hand, he would have the opportunity to meet all of the great Greek thinkers and heroes. And here he could ask them the same questions that he asked the men of Athens.

So he has in no way been harmed, for he will either sleep soundly or continue talking.

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